

Anatomy of an Artist Statement

by Caleb Sobolewski

“Artist Statement Statement”
Caleb Sobolewski
Artist Statement

1.

The statement begins with single sentence, serving as an introduction to the other content of the paragraph.

This typically houses the title, mediums, and themes of the work, as well as an intent (either stylistically or logistically).

3.

The statement concludes with a summary. This often begins with a cliché phrase such as “In essence” or a prepositional phrase such as “By...”. This sentence serves as a synopsis and leaves viewers with a lasting memory.

1.

The artist statement is a form of accessible writing to inform viewers, with both professional and amateur frameworks of contemporary art culture, on the topics, inspirations, and methods in which a work has been created.

Crafted with deliberate language and coded phrases, observers will engage with a piece in fundamentally differing ways as compared to a similar experience negating the statement. Perfected in an age of politically-charged artwork, the statement aims to contextualize.

2.

3.

In essence, the artist statement transforms an otherwise passive viewer into an attentive witness, allowing them to further comprehend a piece.

Other Characteristics

- Short Version
 - Less than 100 words
- Long Version
 - Less than 1000 words
- Self-referencing
 - Either current or previous works
- Use of “I” and “My”
- May pose more questions than answers
- Intended to cause introspection

2.

Traditionally, the body of the statement houses the further explanation that fully contextualizes the work. Artists will mention inspirations, such as other work that is stylistically replicated, phenomena they wish to examine, or stories they aim to tell.

There is emphasis on coded language, such as styles (Bauhaus, still life, post-modern, etc.), as well as powerful verbs to intensify the value of the work’s theme.

Professional artists tend to break the rules of the traditional statement, while students often stick to the basics and commonly used phrases.

Commonly used sentence starters include:

- “I am to capture...”
- “My work explores...”
- “I seek to evoke...”